In the Driver's Seat

The Vande Bharat Express has a small cab with a very large windscreen. At 130 kmph, the trackside softens at the edges, signals appear and disappear within seconds, and a delayed reaction can make all the difference. Even today, many still see it as a "man's job". But in Southern Railway's Chennai Division, that responsibility is often Aiswarya S. Menon's. "It is not just about driving a train. It is about taking hundreds of people to their destinations safely and on time," says the senior assistant loco pilot.

WHAT MAKES HER A SHERO

Entering a profession long dominated by men, Aiswarya has mastered the controls of the Vande Bharat and emerged as one of India's standout young loco pilots



AISWARYA S. MENON, 33
Senior Assistant Loco Pilot, Vande Bharat
Moozhikulam, Kerala

Aiswarya, from Moozhikulam near Aluva in Kerala, joined Indian Railways in 2019 almost by accident. An electrical engineer by training, she had initially appeared for an air force exam before qualifying for the railway job. "That was when it began to sink in that I was going to be driving trains, and how unconventional and exciting that would be," she recalls. At about 2,000, women account for less than 2 per cent of the more than 107,000 loco pilots in Indian Railways.

Having lost her father early, Aiswarya was raised by her mother, who initially worried about night duties and safety. "Over time, she got used to it," she says. Her husband's support has also been crucial. "Man or woman, no loco pilot can do this job without the support and understanding of family," she adds.

Loco pilots work to rotating schedules, have no fixed weekends, and alertness must be sustained for the entire journey. Her disciplined approach to signalling and consistent performance caught the attention of senior officials. When Vande Bharat services were introduced on Southern Railway in 2022, she was among the pilots assigned to the prestigious trains and has operated the Chennai-Coimbatore and Chennai-Vijayawada services.

HER TAKE

"Know that a woman can do any job"

Today, Aiswarya has logged more than 2,000 hours of footplating—the railway term for working in the locomotive cab. In June 2024, she was one of 10 loco pilots invited as special guests to the swearing-in ceremony of Prime Minister Narendra Modi. "I was like, why me? What special thing have I done?" she recalls, with the faint disbelief of someone who still sees herself less as a symbol of change and more as a loco pilot just doing her job. ■

—Avishek G. Dastidar